

Moroccan women gather the health-giving fruits of the argan tree. These trees in the Arganeraie Biosphere Reserve are carefully sustained by the local population.

Conflicting opinions

The sites of the WBNR, as well as being of international scientific significance, are often culturally important to the host state. They are not nominated by UNESCO, but by national governments, and they remain under the jurisdiction of the states they are in. International recognition of their status does not impinge upon the rights of those states over the Biosphere Reserves.

In recent years, some states have chosen to manage certain sites as national rather than international reserves and have withdrawn them from the program. Nevertheless, there has been a steady increase in sites nominated for the program from governments around the world.